OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Questions to Mayor White on Shoalhaven's $5.6 million waste levy claim

Sent 9 October 2026 · To Mayor White · Response requested by 24 October 2026

10 October 2026

Cr Patricia White
Mayor, Shoalhaven City Council
Bridge Road, Nowra NSW 2541

Copy: Mr Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer

Your letter to the Minister on the Metropolitan Waste Levy: questions on the claims

Dear Mayor,

I write about the Council media release on your letter to the Hon. Penny Sharpe MLC seeking Shoalhaven's removal from the Metropolitan Levy Area. The 2018 inquiry did recommend reclassification, and the Audit Office did find that the levy boundaries lack objective, transparent criteria. The case for scrutiny of the boundary is fair. Several of the figures and statements in the release, however, are not supported by anything Council has published. Residents should be able to test them.

Please answer the following:

1. The $5.6 million and $93 per household. What is the source and calculation for each figure? What was the total levy paid in 2025-26, by which Council facilities, and how many rateable households were used as the divisor? Is the levy recovered through the domestic waste management charge, and if so, how much of the $2.37 million saving would be passed back to ratepayers?

1. "Independent reviews have repeatedly questioned that decision." Which reviews, other than the 2018 inquiry and the Audit Office report, are you relying on? The Audit Office report examined the levy generally. Did it address Shoalhaven specifically?

1. What the release left out. Why did the release not mention that the NSW Government's waste levy review is under way, that it may change boundaries in either direction, or that the Minister sat on the 2018 committee whose recommendation you cite? Was a response to that recommendation ever received, and what did it say?

1. The $38 million Materials Recovery Facility. What is the cost of the facility alone, separate from other works? What tonnage has it processed and what revenue has it earned since it opened in March? Is any external customer under a signed contract, and at what price per tonne compared with the domestic waste fund?

1. **MRF profit. The 2026-27 budget forecasts about $3.3 million in first-year profit, which depends on outside tonnage. Where will that profit be recorded: in the waste reserve, or in the General Fund operating result? How does Council reconcile seeking relief from the levy for ratepayers while budgeting for a commercial surplus from the same facility?**

1. **“One of the most comprehensive regional resource recovery systems in Australia.” What benchmark or independent assessment supports this statement?**

I would appreciate a written reply by 24 October 2026. Any response may be published in full on Eye on Shoalhaven Council, alongside this letter.

Yours sincerely,

Steven
Eye on Shoalhaven Council
